

4.14.2 Using a level of response mark scheme

Level of response mark schemes are broken down into a number of levels, each of which has a descriptor. The descriptor for the level shows the average performance for the level. There are a range of marks in each level. The descriptor for the level represents a typical mid-mark performance in that level.

Before applying the mark scheme to a student's project, read it through and annotate it to show the qualities that are being looked for. You can then apply the mark scheme.

4.14.2.1 Step 1 Determine a level

Start at the lowest level of the mark scheme and use it as a ladder to see whether the performance in that section of the project meets the descriptor for that level. The descriptor for the level indicates the different qualities that might be seen in the student's work for that level. If it meets the lowest level then go to the next one and decide if it meets this level, and so on, until you have a match between the level descriptor and the work. With practice and familiarity you will find you will be able to quickly skip through the lower levels of the mark scheme.

When assigning a level you should look at the overall quality of the work rather than any small or specific parts where the student has not performed quite as the level descriptor. If the work covers different aspects of different levels of the mark scheme you should use a best fit approach for defining the level and then use the variability of the response to help decide the mark within the level. ie if the response is predominantly level 3 with a small amount of level 4 material it would be placed in level 3 but be awarded a mark near the top of the level because of the level 4 content.

4.14.2.2 Step 2 Determine a mark

Once you have assigned a level you need to decide on the mark. The exemplar materials used for standardisation will help. This work will have been awarded a mark by AQA. You can compare your student's work with the exemplar to determine if it is the same standard, better or worse. You can then use this to allocate a mark for the work based on AQA's mark on the exemplar.

You may well need to read back through the work as you apply the mark scheme to clarify points and assure yourself that the level and the mark are appropriate.

Work which contains nothing of relevance to the project area being assessed must be awarded no marks for that area.